THE EFFECTS OF IMMIGRANT DISPERSION POLICIES IN MEXICO

A theoretical approximation
and data analysis



MEXICO CITY
2026



Written and translated by: Liliana Frankel

Editor: Santiago Narváez

Data analysis: Liliana Frankel, Daniel Gómez Hernández, Santiago Narváez

Interactive maps and visualizations: Daniel Gómez Hernández

Design, art, maps, and visuals for report: Liliana Frankel

Open-code check: Sierra Wells, Kathleen Escoto

Public record requests: Santiago Narváez, Liliana Frankel

In-field support at Vallejo camp:

Rodrigo Yedra, Cecilia Rangel López, Liliana Frankel, Santiago Narváez, Alberto Cortés Campos, Keith Dannemiller

This report grew out hundreds of formal and informal conversations we've had with people on the move during fieldwork for the various projects we've worked on together for three years. Although to maintain confidentiality, we are unable to cite all of our interlocutors by name, we are profoundly grateful for their trust and their insights.

We're also so grateful to our colleagues, who shared their perspectives and accompaniment. In particular, we thank Andrew Bahena, Flor Pérez, Danielle Cosmes, Sofía Matus, Luis Armando Pérez López, Michele Cannon, and Josué Martínez Leal.

This report was produced collaboratively. It had no dedicated funding, and was fueled instead by sincere human interest and our belief in its binational importance.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

1. Executive summary and key findings 5

2. A short history of immigration containment in Mexico 7

3. Trends in immigration transfers in Mexico 9

4. Voices of families on the move 14

5. Current implications 18

6. Appendix: Methodology and data dictionary 20

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY AND KEY FINDINGS

This report seeks to theorize and analyze dispersion trends in Mexico from 2017-2024. We use the term “dispersion” to refer to the new geographies created by immigration containment, which has rerouted people on the move in Mexico away from their traditional destinations. This rerouting has been achieved by investing in measures like highway checkpoints, surveillance technologies, and caravan interception – interlocking pieces of a militarized infrastructure[1] which continues to gain ground. Immigration containment infrastructure has not only slowed the arrival of new immigrants to the US’s southern border, but also reorganized transit migration routes and dispersed immigrants throughout the territories they control.

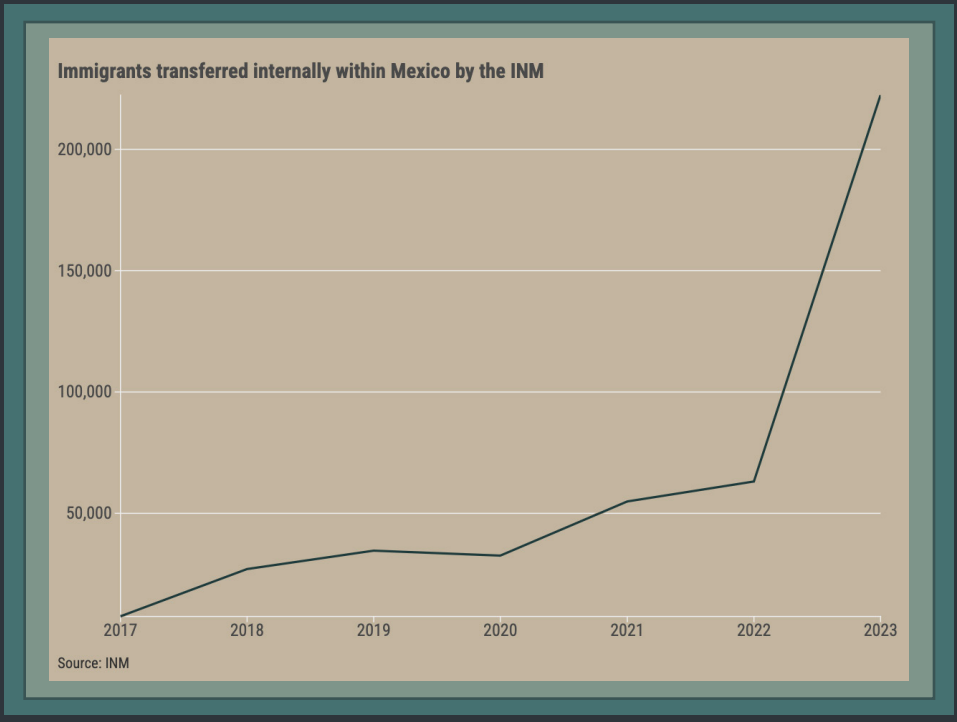
A primary example of this trend is Mexico’s National Immigration Institute [INM]’s reliance on overland transfers between detention sites. Our analysis relies primarily on a database of such transfers that we obtained through an information request[2] to the INM. These records show the origin and destination of all[3] internal transfers conducted between January 2017 and June 2024. Each of the more than 10,000 transfers documented also includes demographic data for the people aboard, including the nationalities present, their sexes, and the number of adults vs. minors.

In total, we documented the internal transfer of 483,190 immigrants from 2017 to 2024, with a noticeable uptick in 2023. We did not request deportation data, but 99,332 people were also registered in the database as deportees from Mexico to another country during the same period. In 2023, the last year for which we have a full set of data, internal transfers affected almost 30 times as many people as in 2017.

In order to define categories for our analysis, we relied on conversations with people on the move who have experienced dispersion firsthand. We theorize that the “top-down dispersion” that has occurred as the INM has distanced hundreds of thousands of immigrants from their destinations has also provoked an “organic dispersion”, in which people on the move have tended to take increasingly clandestine routes in order to avoid being apprehended by the INM, the Mexican National Guard and the Mexican Army.

We shared our preliminary findings with immigrant residents of the camp along the Ferrocarril Industrial in Colonia Vallejo in Mexico City in August 2026, who added that the INM’s internal transfers also constitute a practice that violates their human rights:

- Transfers can make it impossible for detainees to communicate with worried family for days; in this sense, they are indistinguishable from a forced disappearance.
- The ambiguous juridical norms governing transfers create ambiguous practices on the ground which can lead to family separation. This threatens the best interest of the child,



which is a guiding principle of Mexican immigration law.

- When adults in a family are subject to immigration checkpoints, transfers can affect Mexican-born youth and babies.

Even after Mexico prohibited holding minors in immigration detention centers in 2020, the INM has continued including them in its internal transfers. The number of immigrant youth affected between 2020 and 2023 actually increased nearly eightfold. In total, we documented the internal transfers of 64,763 babies, children and teens between 2017 and 2024.

Transfers are not an alternative to immigrant detention, rather a practice that feeds people on the move into detention centers. We documented that 89.8% of internal transfers concluded in a municipality with some type of detention center, whether it was what Mexico calls a "Provisional Shelter" or a "Migration Station". In interviews, people on the move recounted how INM transfers almost always ended with their on-site detention, which would last at least the 36 hours to which it was limited by a court ruling in 2023.[4] Prior to this ruling, immigration detention in Mexico was legally permitted to last for 48 hours in Type A Provisional Shelters, 7 days in Type B Provisional Shelters, and indefinitely in Migration Stations.[5]

A second information request[6] regarding the period from 2024-2026 showed that although the INM's internal transfers have diminished in frequency since the changes of administration in Mexico and the US, top-down dispersion has continued, with 382 transfers completed in the first half of 2026.

Of the 437 different overland transfer routes documented from 2017 to 2024, two of the most popular set out from Mexico's northern border with the US and ended in Villahermosa, Tabasco. This observation squares with media[7] and NGO reports[8] which show that since at least 2021, the INM has not only received returned third-country immigrants at the US border, but has also actively participated in transferring them to its southern border states.

As of today, no official explanation exists for why the government of Mexico is collaborating with the US government to internally disperse deported immigrants. The practice of transferring deported immigrants to Villahermosa, Tabasco and Tapachula, Chiapas has affected both third-country deportees and Mexican nationals.

For our immigrant interviewees, dispersion can be understood as a key element of a militarized system that profits from their containment, whether in geopolitical terms or literally, through the collusion of corrupt officials with organized crime networks.

1. We use "infrastructure" in a similar sense to that developed by Bingham et al., 2025, in "Digital Migration Control Infrastructure as Worldmaking". *University of St. Thomas Journal of Law and Public Policy*.
2. ID: 330020324000863
3. Those the INM shared in response to our request for the complete dataset, although the internal inconsistencies of the data we received and its differences from responses to similar queries by colleagues suggest highly imprecise documentation practices and the likelihood of significant omissions.
4. Suprema Corte de Justicia de la Nación, 2023. "Tesis: Detención Administrativa Migratoria". *Semanario Judicial de la Federación.* https://sjf2.scjn.gob.mx/detalle/tesis/2027175; INM, 2023. "Suspende INM temporalmente Estancias Provisionales en el país". Gobierno de México. https://www.gob.mx/inm/prensa/suspende-inm-temporalmente-estancias-provisionales-en-el-pais
5. ID: 340020300107526
6. Huerta García, 2026. "México gastó, al menos, 13.5 millones de pesos en trasladar a cubanos deportados desde Estados Unidos". *El Toque.* https://eltoque.com/documentos-revelan-red-de-traslados-de-cubanos-deportados-a-mx; Ochoa Argüello, 2021. "Supera Aeropuerto de Tapachula Más de 40 Mil Pasajeros en Mes de Agosto". *EL ORBE.* https://elorbe.com/seccion-politica/local/2021/09/11/supera-aeropuerto-de-tapachula-mas-de-40-mil-pasajeros-en-mes-de-agosto.html
7. Isacson et al., 2026. "Banished to the South: The Human Cost of Deportation". WOLA. https://www.wola.org/analysis/banished-to-the-south-the-human-cost-of-deportation/; 2026. "'Casting Us Aside to Die': Cuban and Other Third-

Country Nationals Deported from the US to Mexico". Human Rights Watch. https://www.hrw.org/report/2026/05/27/casting-us-aside-to-die/cuban-and-other-third-country-nationals-deported-from-the

"Chaos has its peculiar structural advantages..."
- Eyal Weizman, cited in Hiemstra, 2013[1]

A SHORT HISTORY OF IMMIGRATION CONTAINMENT IN MEXICO

While the US has promoted both immigration and Cold War containment policies in Mexico for decades, recent histories of Mexican immigration policy tend to identify a turning point: the migrant caravans of 2018. These exoduses went viral and provoked tariff threats[2] from the US's former and current president, Donald Trump, who characterized them as an "invasion".[3]

By 2019, the new Mexican president, Andrés Manuel López Obrador [AMLO] began to take steps to dissuade transit migration, initiating formal collaboration between the recently created National Guard and the INM to man checkpoints and conduct raids and surveillance.[4] AMLO's administration also worked with the US on programming to discourage people on the move from applying for asylum futher north. For example, he accepted the installation of the program Remain in Mexico on the northern border with the US.[5] He also rebranded a temporary work program begun by his predecessor which incentivized immigrants to apply for asylum in the Mexican Commission for Refugee Assistance [COMAR] offices on the southern border. The resolution of such applications is conditioned on the asylum seeker remaining in the locality where they file, until, up to a year later, they receive a final decision.[6]



Frankel, 2024

Such immigration containment policies have tended to prolong the stays of people on the move in Mexico without providing them with full access to their rights, and the situation has only gotten worse in the past two years. After the de facto closing of the US/Mexico border and US funding cuts to the UN and USAID, processing times for asylum applications at COMAR have grown even longer,[7] complicating matters for asylum seekers who are meanwhile left without formal work permission and only limited access to local ID, healthcare, education and justice systems.

The INM's transfers are a major mechanism through which immigration containment is enacted in Mexico, but their particular role within the spectrum of related strategies has not been well analyzed. The INM's opaque and shifting public statements suggest that the transfers are an ad-hoc strategy that can serve a variety of political ends. Purely logistical justifications for top-down dispersion are not supported by the data.

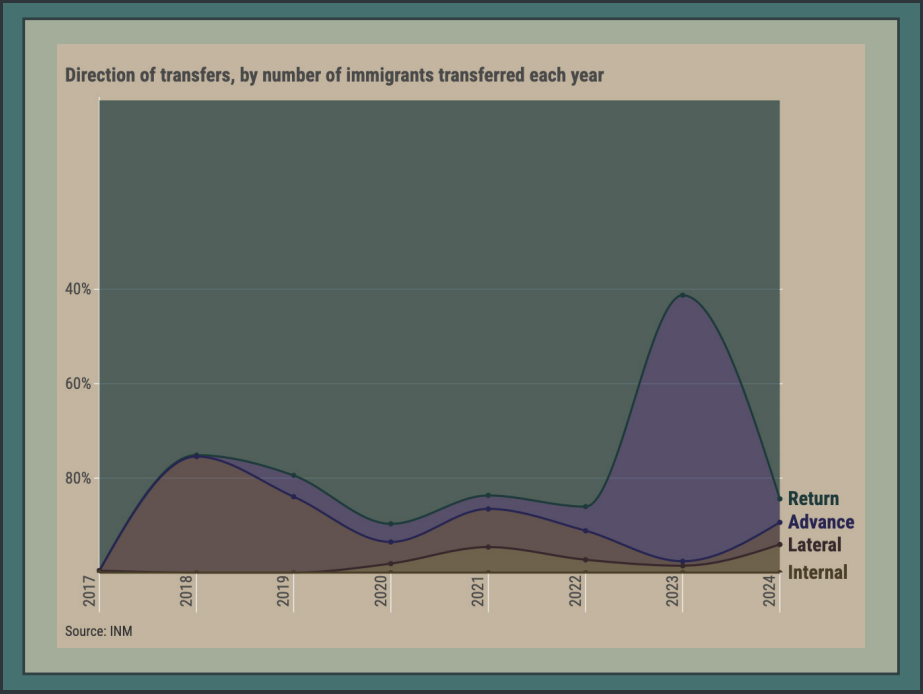
With the information available, we can affirm that the INM's internal transfers appear to have assumed a central role in Mexico's immigration containment stategies in response to intense pressure from the US to stop immigrants crossing the country from continuing their journeys north. The recently published memoir of the US ambassador to Mexico under Joe Biden, Ken Salazar, describes the US's involvment in the expansion of these dispersion policies. It highlights his own personal exhortations to AMLO to finance the transfers,[8] and describes how pausing and restarting INM transfers at the end of 2023 was the leverage AMLO needed to secure a rare visit from then-Secretary of State Antony Blinken to discuss matters of bilateral importance.[10]

Salazar's emphasis on INM transfers confirms that they are seen as a key tool to enforce immigration containment, and that their intention is profoundly punitive. Top-down dispersion is part of what Mexican civil society has termed a policy of "wearing down": beyond simply containing immigrants within certain geographic areas, they have a deterrent effect achieved by inflicting great logistical and emotional chaos. INM transfers distance people on the move from their networks and resources while also overburdening receiving territories, which do not receive the necessary federal funding to invest in social programs that would foster integration, nor in infrastructure for local development.



1. Hiemstra, 2013. "'You don't even know where you are': Chaotic Geographies of US Migrant Detention and Deportation". Carceral Spaces: Mobility and Agency in Imprisonment and Migrant Detention.
2. 2025. "La amenaza de los aranceles: Trump recurre a la misma táctica que ocupó en 2019 contra México para obtener acuerdos migratorios". N+ Univisión. https://www.univision.com/local/washington-dc-wfdc/trump-amenaza-aranceles-mexico-migracion-2025
3. Mealer, 2018. "This is what Trump's caravan 'invasion' really looks like". The Guardian. https://www.theguardian.com/us-news/2018/nov/26/migrant-caravan-disabled-children
4. García Alanis, 2024. "La militarización del Instituto Nacional de Migración y sus implicaciones en las violaciones a derechos humanos de las personas migrantes". PRAMI. https://prami.ibero.mx/wp-content/uploads/2024/04/Informe-Militarizacion-INM_2024.pdf
5. Garibo, 2023. "#RealidadesMPP: Documentación de violaciones a DDHH de personas solicitantes de asilo devueltas a Tijuana en 2022". PRAMI. https://prami.ibero.mx/wp-content/uploads/2023/09/REALIDADES-MPP_26-SEP-23.pdf
6. Garrapa, 2022. "El éxodo centroamericano entre inserción laboral y militarización en la frontera sur de México". European Review of Latin American and Caribbean Studies.
7. Xantomila, 2016. "Tras arduos procesos, migrantes varados en el país regularizan estancia". La Jornada. https://www.jornada.com.mx/2026/06/20/politica/004n1pol
8. Salazar, 2026. *Borderlands: My Fight for an Inclusive America.*
9. Ibid, p. 278; p. 282.
10. Ibid, p. 283.

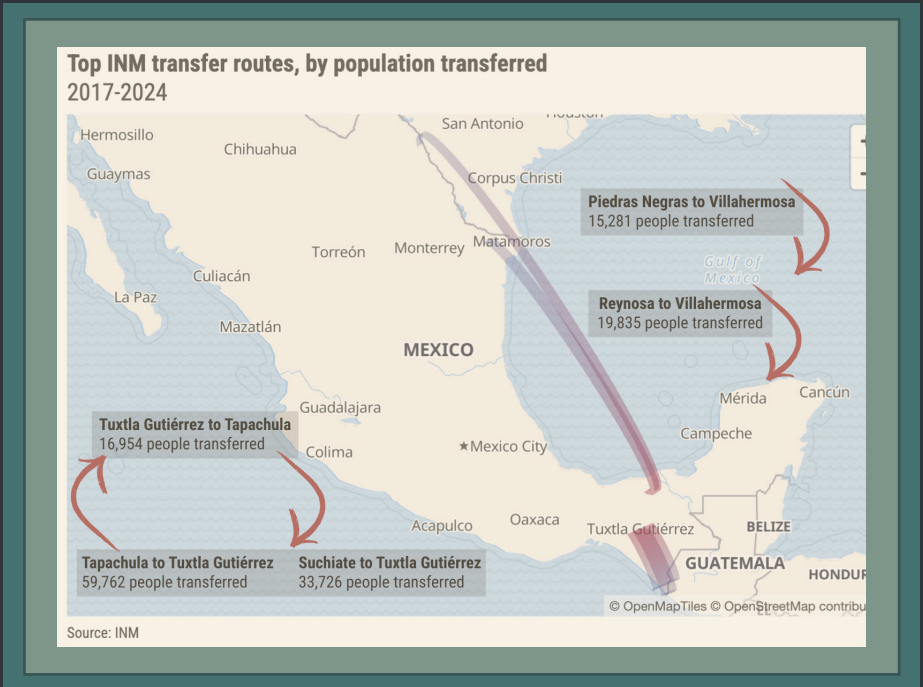
TRENDS IN IMMIGRATION TRANSFERS IN MEXICO



A majority of people on the move transferred between 2017 and June 2024 were returned from north to south, but a third of those registered in our database were transferred north, or towards a parallel site. These transfers likely represent the dispersion of:

- People detained during a raid, a sweep, or the interception of a caravan
- People in the process of being deported, with additional pickups at several points along the way
- People transferred because authorities were seeking to loosen the pressure put on overcrowded southern border cities where many immigrants were being contained[1]

The routes along which the greatest numbers of immigrants were internally transferred from 2017 to 2024 are the following:



With these trends identified, we can now make a few observations about the characteristics of top-down dispersion in Mexico.

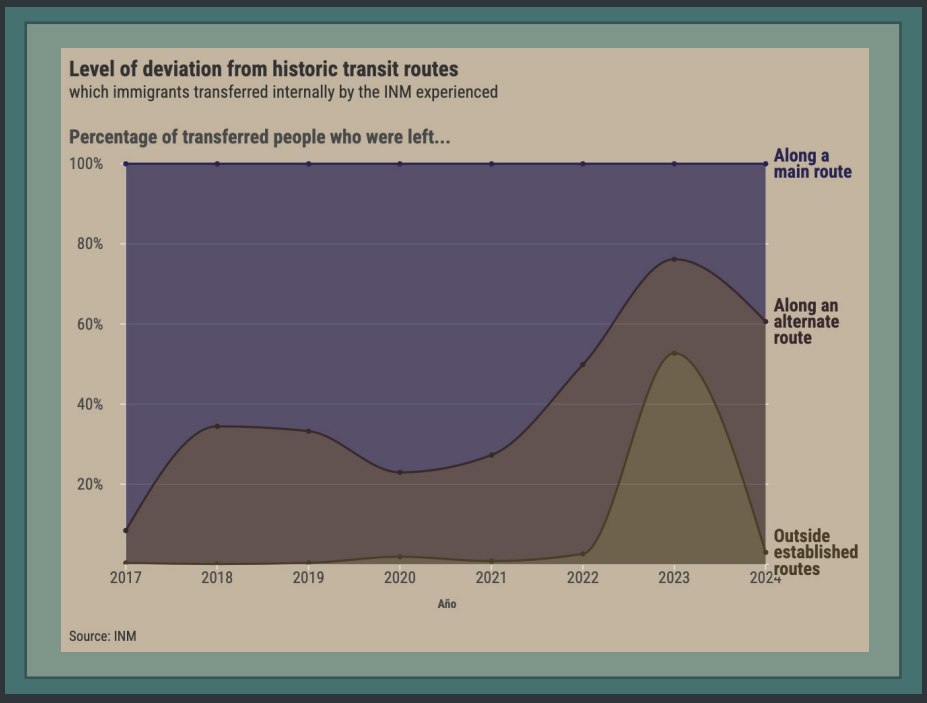
Firstly, the prevalence of an INM transfer loop in Chiapas demonstrates that dispersion was not serving a strictly practical role in immigration control from 2017 to 2024. In 2023, we conducted monitoring in Viva México, a site within Tapachula's municipal limits where immigrants could sign up to board INM transfers to Tuxtla Gutiérrez. These trips, which to them represented the possibility of advancing towards their destination, for many immigrants would instead end with their eventual transfer back to Tapachula.

For years, the freight train known as La Bestia was the most reliable mode of transport for immigrants crossing Mexico to get to the US. As such, it is

noteworthy that amongst the five most common INM transfer routes documented, four end in Tuxtla Gutiérrez, Chiapas and Villahermosa, Tabasco – southern capitals through which La Bestia does not pass. While Villahermosa is at least on the highway route from southern Tabasco's border with Guatemala towards the Gulf port of Coatzacoalcos, Tuxtla Gutiérrez is not an obligatory stop on any of the historic routes from southern Chiapas towards the Isthmus of Tehuantepec.



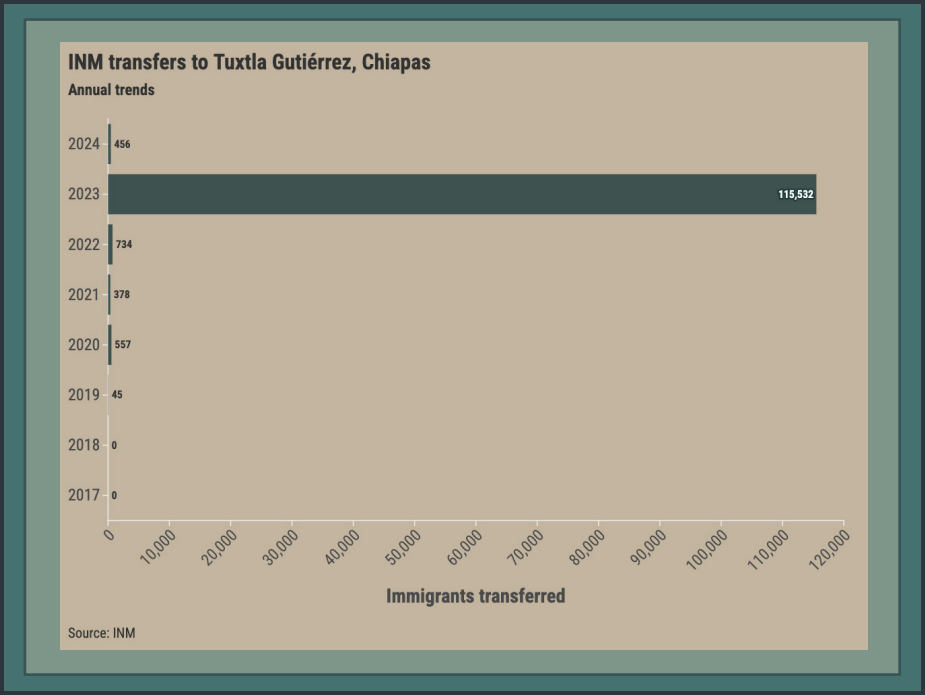
Methodology: p. 23



The presence in the database of trends as specific as the 2023 transfers of more than 100,000 detained immigrants to Tuxtla Gutiérrez, Chiapas' capital, suggests just how flexible the strategy of top-down dispersion has been. INM transfers to Tuxtla Gutiérrez took place overwhelming that year; in 2024, the city went back to receiving hundreds, rather than thousands, of transferred people. The transfers deposited an immigrant population equivalent to about 15% the local population of Tuxtla Gutiérrez[2], even though it wasn't historically part of transit immigration routes or routes for INM transfers.

According to the National Commission for Human Rights [CNDH], Tuxtla Gutiérrez has a Type B Provisional Shelter – an INM temporary detention center – which local news reports say was inaugurated in October 2022.[4] After Tuxtla Gutiérrez received so many immigrants transferred by the INM the following year, a COMAR office was opened as well in December 2023.[5]

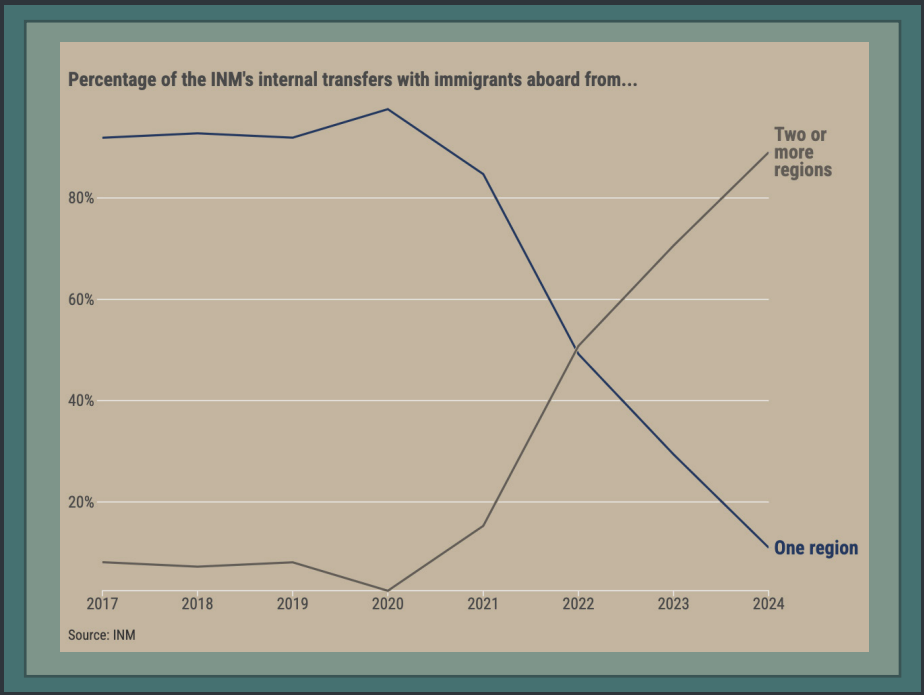
Altogether, we can observe how the inauguration of a new space to detain people on the move in Tuxtla Gutiérrez allowed for the expansion of INM transfers to a new territory, while a corresponding institutional investment in services directed at asylum seekers would take longer to arrive.



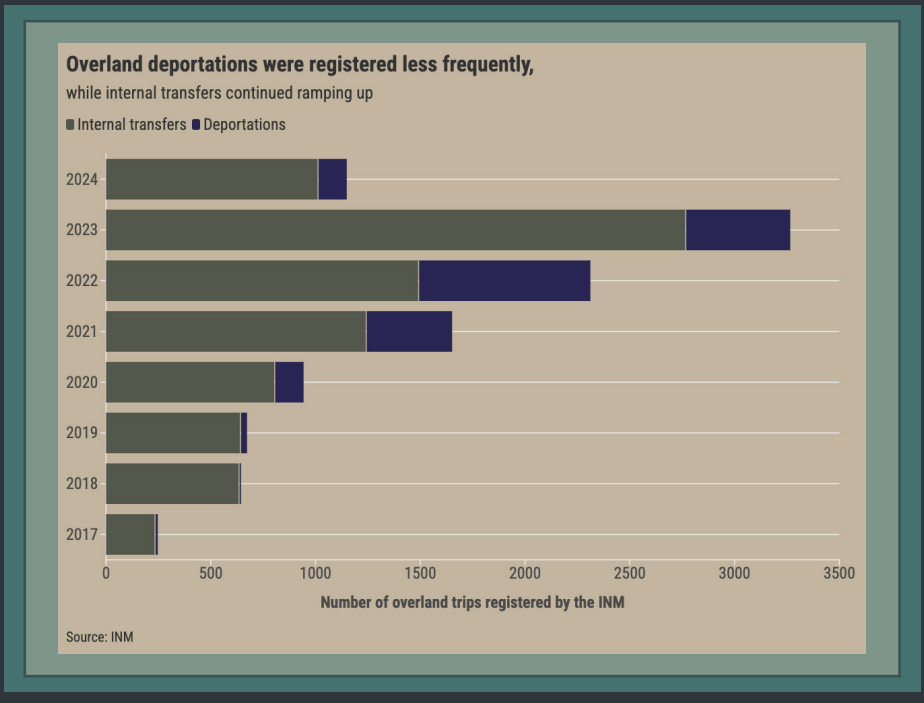
It's also worth noting that once a COMAR office was opened there, Tuxtla Gutiérrez stopped being the top destination for immigrants transferred by the INM. In 2024, Villahermosa, Tabasco resumed that title. Even now, Villahermosa doesn't have its own COMAR office, and asylum seekers there must complete their paperwork through the INM.[6]

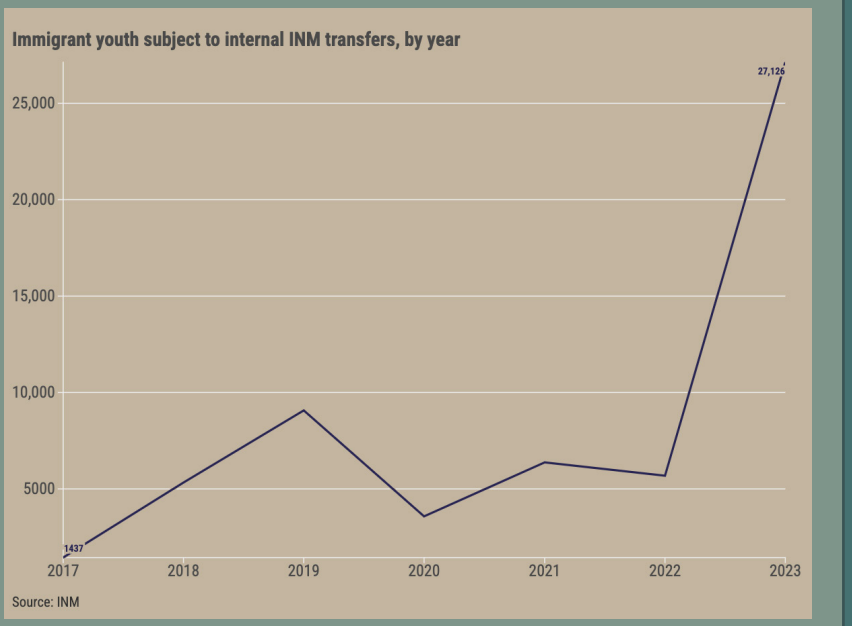
Although we cannot confirm the intention behind these strategic adjustments, their effects on transferred immigrants are punitive. The shifting geography of top-down dispersion has distanced immigrants from the institutions best equipped to supervise their asylum applications, even as asylum continues to be the only legal provision that permits undocumented immigrants without significant financial resources to adjust their legal status, move freely within the Republic, and find formal employment.

As transit migration has diversified, so too have INM transfers. In 2017, when 91.9% of transfers included only immigrants from one given region at a time, it was easier for the INM to argue that these trips represented a necessary logistical step in order to concentrate immigrants awaiting deportation in certain Migration Stations prior to their removal. By 2024, on the other hand, 89% of transfers included more diverse groups, made up of immigrants from multiple regions of origin.

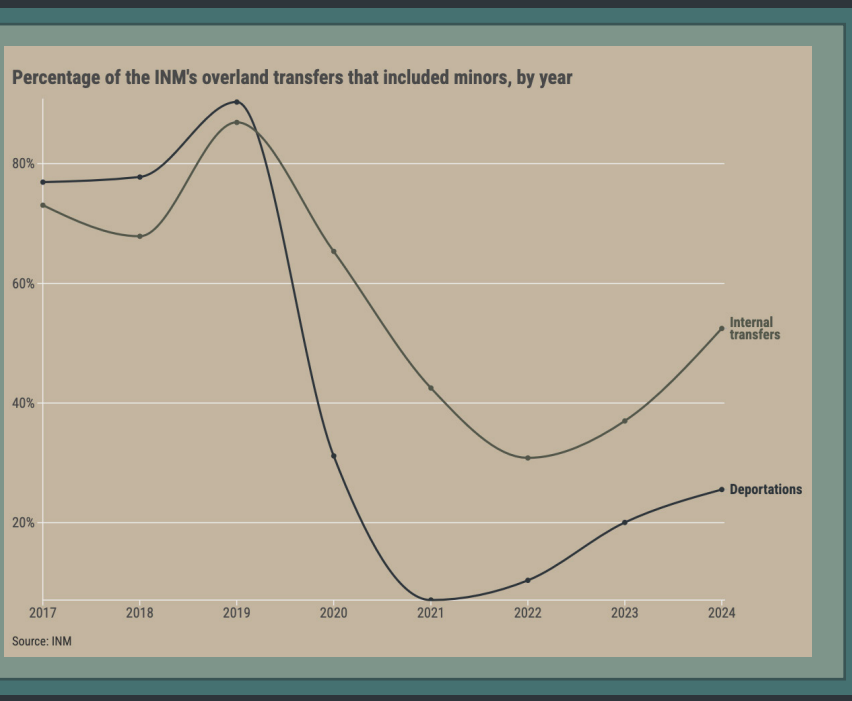


The diversification of INM transfers further suggests that after the pandemic, the INM began to plan its transfers mainly as part of a strategy to disorient and exhaust people on the move; it supports our observation that the transfers do not seem to support a specific logistical outcome, like consolidating immigrants in specific detention centers prior to deporting them, or providing assistance or programming to particular groups. Although we didn't request deportation records, some were included in the INM database we received. As such, we can observe that in 2023 and 2024, both the number of deportations registered and their proportion versus internal transfers decreased.





Without a clear objective, top-down dispersion can be understood partly as a performance of compliance for US authorities who pressured Mexico to participate in the externalization of the shared border in sovereign national territory. The INM's transfers instrumentalized people on the move for geopolitical ends, resulting in broad human rights violations and breaking with the principles of protection laid out in both Mexican law and international agreements.



On a national level, top-down dispersion also allowed the INM to simulate a reduction in punitive measures directed at immigrant minors. In 2020, the holding of minors in Migration Stations was formally prohibited;[7] nonetheless, their detention and transfer have persisted unimpeded by legal challenges. During the years with the greatest numbers of families in transit through Mexico, the numbers of immigrant youth affected by INM transfers grew exponentially.

1. As referenced in PRAMI, 2022. *#COMUNICADO Ante la desinformación sobre trámites por parte del INM, cientos de personas pasan la noche en situación de calle en Tapachula*. https://prami.ibero.mx/comunicado-ante-la-desinformacion-sobre-tramites-por-parte-del-inm-cientos-de-personas-pasan-la-noche-en-situacion-de-calle-en-tapachula/
2. Data México, 2020. "Tuxtla Gutiérrez". Gobierno de México. https://www.economia.gob.mx/datamexico/es/profile/geo/tuxtla-gutierrez-99702
3. CNDH, 2024. "Informe Especial sobre las Condiciones de las Estancias y Estaciones Migratorias: Hacia un Nuevo Modelo para la Atención de la Migración Irregular". CNDH. https://www.cndh.org.mx/sites/default/files/documentos/2024-02/INFORME%20ESPECIAL%20ESTANCIAS%20MIGRATORIAS.pdf

4. Espinosa, 2022. “INM inaugura nueva Estación Migratoria en Tuxtla Gutiérrez, Chiapas”. Capital. https://www.capitalmexico.com.mx/estados/inm-inaugura-nueva-estacion-migratoria-en-tuxtla-gutierrez-chiapas
5. 2023. “COMAR inaugura oficina en Tuxtla para fortalecer atención a personas refugiadas”. El Heraldo de Chiapas. https://oem.com.mx/elheraldodechiapas/local/comar-inaugura-oficina-en-tuxtla-13189815 Folio 340020300107526
6. 2024. “Directorio COMAR”. Gobierno de México. https://www.gob.mx/comar/articulos/directorio-comar
7. 2020. “Los niños migrantes en México ya no estarán encerrados en los centros de acogida”. Programa Universitario de Derechos Humanos, UNAM. https://www.pudh.unam.mx/perseo/los-ninos-migrantes-en-mexico-ya-no-estaran-encerrados-en-los-centros-de-acogida/

VOICES OF FAMILIES ON THE MOVE

Reyna,[1] a Venezuelan woman, shared how she was separated from her adolescent daughter, María, during an INM raid on the train where they were traveling near Monclova, Coahuila in 2024. She and the rest of her family were detained and transferred to Villahermosa, Tabasco, while María stayed behind in the desert:

> ***“We ran so hard, running, jumping fences. My partner ran with our son hanging onto him, he passed him to me, I grabbed him…There, we hid amongst the nopal cacti…The INM, the police, the National Guard, and the Marines were all there, pointing their weapons at us.***
>
> ***…My daughter was hiding nearby in a different spot. And my partner and I were detained…So then, when they took me away and they put me on the INM bus…I start crying and I tell the agent that my daughter was left behind. And he says, ‘Why didn’t you say anything in the moment when we could’ve looked for her?’ Because when we left home, she said, ‘Mom, if they get you, don’t give me up. Let me go on.’”***

Later, the staff of a humanitarian organization in Piedras Negras realized that María was a minor and transferred her to the local System for Integral Family Development [DIF], the Mexican agency which serves orphans and children removed from their parents’ custody. Reyna said that she received a call from a lawyer, who led her to believe that she was authorizing the organization to help her daughter enter the US, where she could stay with an uncle.

Instead, Maria was transferred to a children’s shelter in Coahuila where she would be held against her will for three months. During this period, Reyna said she could only speak with her by phone on four occasions; she spent the rest of the time in agonizing uncertainty.

The forceful separation of a family pursued through the desert at gunpoint and put on a bus by INM agents seems to have been interpreted by DIF staff in the same terms as if Reyna had willfully abandoned her daughter. It would take months of bureaucratic processes and advocacy from Reyna for the INM to coordinate the transfer of María to Tabasco to reunite the family.

Once they were together again, Reyna’s family spent the following seven months attempting to return to Mexico City. When they finally were able to make it, it was through a clandestine sea route. The family opted for organic dispersion after the traumas of the INM’s top-down dispersion.

Anahí, another Venezuelan woman, shared that in 2024, she was detained with her family by INM agents near La Ventosa, Oaxaca. At the time, she was traveling with her daughter-in-law, who was pregnant. Anahí shared that INM agents gave them only a few crackers to eat during the eight hours they were kept waiting aboard the bus that would be used for their transfer.

The bus was scheduled to arrive to Tapachula, Chiapas, but due to conflicts with the immigrants being returned south, Anahí said the INM cut the journey short in Tonalá. Upon arriving, the family realized that the agents had robbed a bag of theirs with new clothes and shoes. They began to travel north again and eventually reached Mexico City, where they settled to wait for their CBP One appointment, but they were unable to complete the process prior to the application's conversion into CBP Home and the de facto end of the right to seek asylum at the US border.[2]

Almost two years later, in 2026, Anahí was apprehended by INM agents while grocery shopping near Tepito. She said she was loaded into a blank white van with her son and one-year-old grandson. The family was transferred to the border with Guatemala, where she said INM agents released them on the bridge and told her "Go back to your country, take the kid to your country." She replied:

> ***"You can't stop him. He is Mexican. This is his country. And that can bother you, or not, but this is his country, man. Sure, he has Venezuelan parents, but he was born here in Mexico. Don't be a brute, don't be ignorant. He is Mexican."***

Anahí, her son and her grandon wanted to proceed to Tapachula, where a caravan was scheduled to leave, but the short journey from the southern border to the city was full of dangers:

> ***"The thing is, there's always the fear and all that of the INM detaining you again, that they could send you back...***
>
> ***[So] we try to go around the other side of Customs, and a pair of guys appear in front of us...[one] with a machete bigger than he is...***
>
> ***No, I said to my son 'Duck and run uphill.' I said, 'Run uphill with the kids.' And I pushed him and took off, they all took off...I stayed below...I couldn't run...A car was coming, I got in the middle of the road, and I heard when one of the guys said 'Leave the lady alone.'"***

Anahí and her family could reach the caravan despite all the difficulties that their organic dispersion had implied.

On the border of Chiapas with Oaxaca, the caravan negotiated with the INM to receive temporary permission to be able to travel within a limited area.

Anahí and her family returned to the life that they were building. Their story highlights the continuity of the infrastructure which informs the INM's internal transfers, even as transit migration in Mexico changes drastically in volume and intention.

Jesús, a Venezuelan man, also lived through an INM transfer in 2026. On the way to work a gig in Toluca (in Mexico state, outside Mexico City) his bus passed through an immigration checkpoint. He said that and his companions were detained and transferred to the closest Migration Station.

In the wee hours of the night, a bus transferring people on the move from the northern border with the US to the southern border with Guatemala stopped at the detention center where Jesús was being held. The officials took advantage of the opportunity to load Jesús and his friends aboard, and they ended up in Villahermosa, Tabasco.

Jesus had been transferred with a colleague and neighbor who is also Venezuelan. She was stopped with the money she had made selling empanadas earlier that day, and she spotted Jesús and his companions until they were able to contact friends and family for support. Jesús's boss paid him the week he was owed, and his daughter also sent him money for his trip. With these funds, Jesús could start making his way

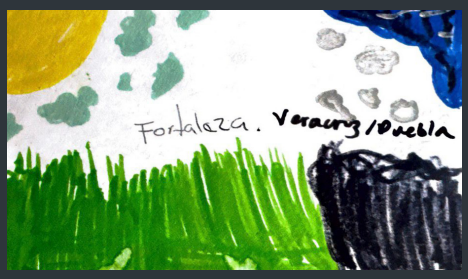
back to Mexico City with his companions.

The group was especially worried about Jesús's neighbor's situation; she is a single mother, and when she was sent to Tabasco, her son was with his babysitter, another neighbor. The babysitter was still taking care of him, but the situation was uncertain.

According to Jesús,

"She called, crying... once we were at the INM office, she was all 'my son, my son.' So, [they said to her] 'What do you want, do you want us to send him after you?'

...And they really did come by the house to investigate and see what was up. So we told [the neighbor taking care of the baby] that no, she shouldn't say anything, because maybe they would take the kid as well... But no one said anything, so the other girl took care of him until we got back and thank God, we were okay."

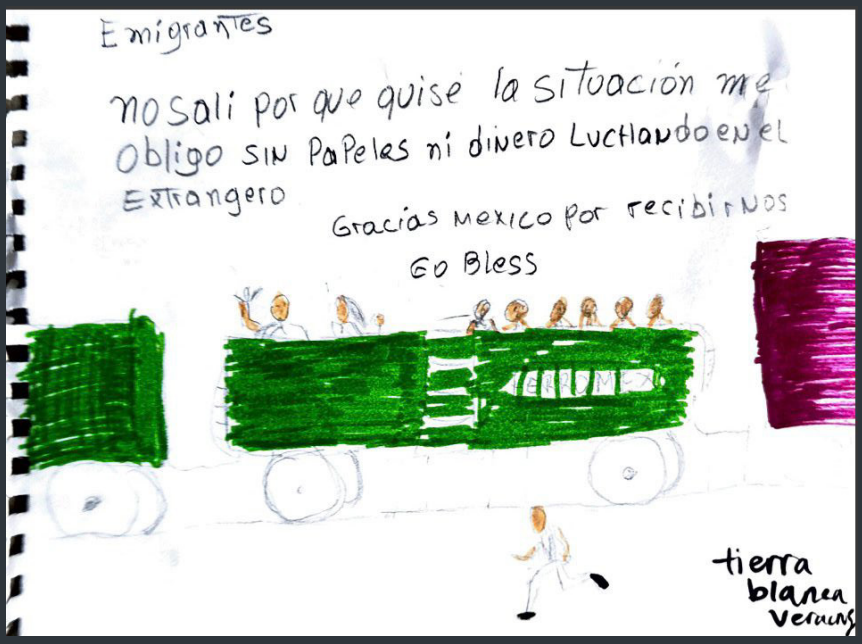


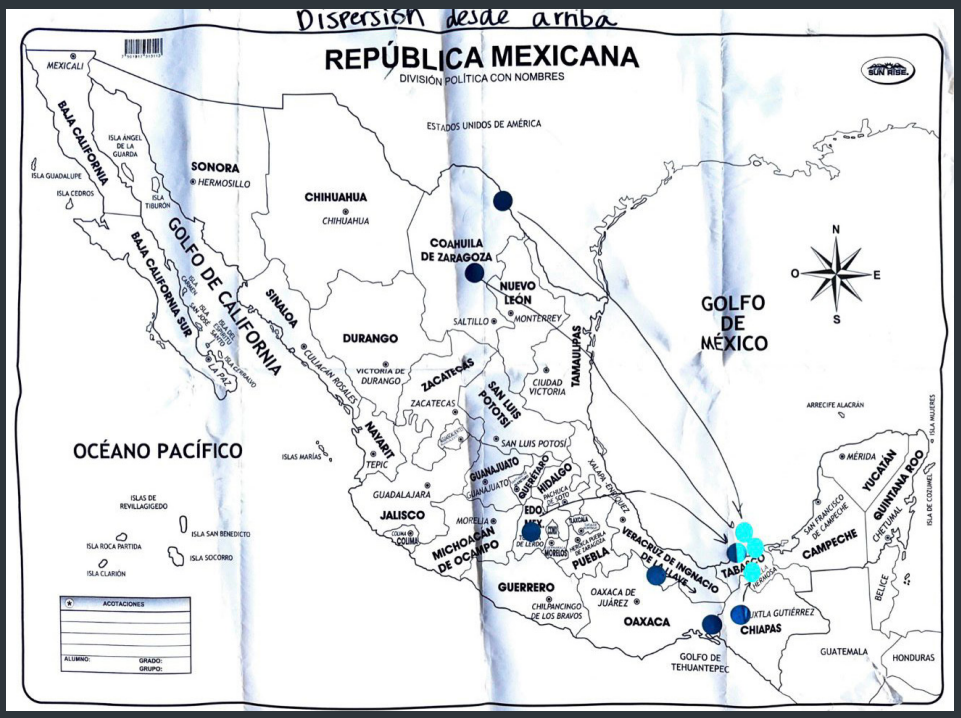


What Jesús remembers most from this experience are the scenes of his organic dispersion, when he took a boat in order to get out Tabasco undetected, and later, when he took La Bestia from Tierra Blanca, Veracruz.

A few of the memories shared in the collective cartography workshop

Vallejo Camp, CDMX
August 2026





This collective cartography of top-down dispersion was compiled together with immigrant residents of the camp at Colonia Vallejo's Ferrocarril Industrial in August 2026. The INM checkpoints (points) and transfers (lines) they said the experienced map onto to some of the most popular transfer routes identified in the official data.

Jesús's story highlights another example of the INM's effects not only on families, but also on the community networks that people on the move develop. Jesús still isn't a Mexican resident, but he has already integrated into a community of other immigrants who have each other's back and can organize in the face of crisis. His transfer to Villahermosa attempted to cut him off from this support network, but thanks to those same connections, he and his neighbor could reunite with their families.



1. The names associated with these testimonies are pseudonyms.
2. 2025. "Trump administration relaunches CBP One asylum app for 'self-deportation'". Al Jazeera. https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2025/3/10/trump-administration-relaunches-cbp-one-asylum-app-for-self-deportation

CURRENT IMPLICATIONS

Official data describe how, from 2017 to 2024, the INM's reliance on the internal transfer of immigrants grew exponentially. This practice is also common in the US, which has been a key source of investment in Mexico's militarization and whose foreign policy has continuously problematized transit migration as a bilateral security issue.[1]

Until now, we haven't seen a thorough breakdown of how these transfers function as part of a set of restrictive immigration and border externalization policies in Mexico. However, this report has been produced in conversation with a corpus of existing literature about dispersion, whose prior theoretical advances have mostly focused on other geographies. We hope it can add to related dialogues between academics, activists and people directly affected by punitive immigration enforcement.

Among the materials we consider referents are various studies detailing prior mechanisms of US border externalization;[2] a boom of recent journalism focusing on the arbitrary transfers of immigrants and racialized people detained within the US this year;[3] maps published by the New York Times which include general data regarding deportations of immigrants from the US to third countries around the world;[4] and the maps and data analysis created by watchdogs like Third Country Deportation Watch[5] and Human Rights First[6], which use open data to track the activities of Immigration and Customs Enforcement [ICE] and Customs and Border Patrol [CBP]. Despite the absence of a formal public agreement, Mexico has been reported as the US's most frequent partner for third-country deportations.[7]

The concept of the "chaotic geographies" produced by immigrant detention and deportations was developed in the US context by Nancy Hiemstra,[8] who also cites the open data project known as Transactional Records Access Clearinghouse [TRAC][9] to emphasize that in the US,

> **"as of 2008, the numbers of transfers that take place per year exceed the number of detainees. Over 50 percent of detainees are transferred at least one time, and one in four detainees is transferred multiple times."**

Isin and Rygiel refer to the diverse geographies created by immigration containment as "other global cities."[10] Missbach names the relationship of spaces for immigration containment with literal detention centers as a "continuum of unfreedom."[11] And De Genova[12] describes how the subjectivity of people on the move is conditioned by their fear of the punitive policies that can result in their detention or deportation, theorizing how detention centers operate within a state of exception.

All of these theoretical advances contribute invaluable context to guide our interpretations, and evidence the role that the INM's transfers play within global trends towards an ever more carceral and punitive system of immigration control.

Nonetheless, we would be remiss if we didn't comment on a few of the particularities of our study situated in the Mexican context. For people on the move here, INM transfers have represented a policy that, instead of working to return them to their home countries, has handed them over to an illicit marketplace where guides with contacts in local government, organized crime or both charge astronomical prices for the promise of their safe passage. For those who can't pay market prices, the risks are even greater: as they disperse themselves through Mexico's wilderness, beaches, wetlands, jungles, mountains, fields, deserts and oceans, immigrants may avoid militarized checkpoints, but they confront environmental dangers and the watchful presence of dangerous local actors who already know their routes.

In this sense, organic dispersion functions as a kickback for organized crime networks, who are the main actors benefiting from the work of moving immigrants between checkpoints. A variety of cases have also been documented in which criminal actors have taken advantage

of the market artificially created by immigration containment to scam,[13] kidnap[14] or, in the worst-case scenario, disappear[15] immigrants who paid them for a path forward. Immigrants are among the populations in Mexico that are most vulnerable to the abuses of organized crime, despite media discourses that prefer to emphasize their complicity. But the responsability to deter crime isn't theirs – it belongs to the government. Organic dispersion is a direct consequence of top-down dispersion, and it is critical that we continue to link the two phenomena as we discuss them, in order to hold the State accountable when its policies put people in danger.

On a governmental level, the INM's transfer network can be understood as another type of infrastructural megaproject. As in the cases of signature projects like the Corredor Transístmico, the Tren Maya, or the Olmeca Refinery, the transfers represent a logistical achievement, in this case for detention and containment, which has reordered national territory towards a very particular vision of modernity. The construction of this new infrastructure has also followed the formula of the State's other megaprojects by promoting collaboration between the civil government, the Army and the National Guard.

The proliferation of immigration checkpoints, surveillance technology, and nationalist and xenophobic discourses across Mexico will continue to facilitate a new degree of territorial control far beyond our current circumstances. And the evident flexibility with which this infrastructure can be used and reoriented is already clear from the case of the INM's participation in US deportations as they transfer third-country migrants to southern cities like Villahermosa, Tabasco and Tapachula, Chiapas.

In future studies, we plan to map another database that we have acquired detailing the INM's aerial transfers, and examine the INM's contracts with private bus operators in order to better understand which actors profit as part of this policy. We invite other reserachers to continue collaborating to develop spatial, geopolitical and economic analyses of transit migration and immigration containment in Mexico.

1. Araiza et al., 2019. "La Implementación y el Legado del Programa Frontera Sur de México". Proyecto de Investigación de Políticas, Escuela de Asuntos Públicos Lyndon B. Johnson. https://www.strausscenter.org/wp-content/uploads/prp_208-LA-IMPLEMENTACI%C3%93N-Y-EL-LEGADO-DEL-PROGRAMA-FRONTERA-SUR-DE-M%C3%89XICO.pdf
2. For example, Loyd & Mountz, 2018. "Boats, Borders, and Bases: Race, the Cold War, and the Rise of Migration Detention in the United States". University of California Press; Fernández Casanueva & Juárez Paulín, 2019. "El punto más al sur y el punto más al norte: Tapachula y Tijuana como ciudades fronterizas escenarios de movilidades forzadas de migrantes, desplazados internos, solicitantes de refugio y deportados". Península, XIV(2), 155-174; Varela Huerta, 2019. "México, de 'frontera vertical' a 'país tapón'. Migrantes, deportados, retornados, desplazados internos y solicitantes de asilo en México". Iberoforum; Hiemstra, 2019. "Pushing the US-Mexico border south: United States' Immigration policing throughout the Americas". Int. J. Migration and Border Studies.
3. For example, Rodríguez & Lopez, 2026. "48 flights – hundreds of detainees: Inside Idaho's ICE transfer network". KTVB7. https://www.ktvb.com/article/news/politics/immigration-news/48-flights-hundreds-detainees-inside-idaho-ice-transfer-network/; Friedman et al., 2026. "ICE transfer flights bring more detainees to Texas where attorneys warn of longer waits". 5NBCDFW. https://www.nbcdfw.com/investigations/ice-transfer-flights-bring-more-detainees-texas-where-attorneys-warn-longer-waits/4021218/.
4. Saha et al, 2025. "Inside the Deportation Machine: How ICE has moved thousands of people through detention and out of the country". The New York Times. https://www.nytimes.com/interactive/2025/12/22/us/trump-immigration-deportation-network-ice-arrests.html
5. 2026. "Third Country Deportation Watch". https://www.thirdcountrydeportationwatch.org/
6. 2026. "ICE Flight Monitor". Human Rights First. https://www.humanrightsfirst.org/ice-flight-monitor
7. Lithnicum, 2026. "Homeless and Stateless: Deportees from the US are Trapped in Mexico". https://www.latimes.com/world-nation/story/2026-03-21/mexico-deportations

8. Hiemstra, 2013. "'You don't even know where you are': Chaotic Geographies of US Migrant Detention and Deportation". Carceral Spaces: Mobility and Agency in Imprisonment and Migrant Detention. Traducción propia.
9. TRAC, 2026. https://tracreports.org/immigration/index.html
10. Isin & Rygiel, 2007. "Of Other Global Cities: Frontiers, Zones, Camps". Cities of the South: Citizenship and Exclusion in the 21st Century, pp. 170-209. Traducción propia.
11. Missbach, 2020. "Substituting immigration detention centres with 'open prisons' in Indonesia: alternatives to detention as the continuum of unfreedom". Citizenship Studies.
12. De Genova, 2016. "Detention, Deportation, and Waiting: Toward a Theory of Migrant Detainability". Global Detention Project. https://www.globaldetentionproject.org/wp-content/uploads/2016/12/De-Genova-GDP-Paper-2016.pdf
13. 2021. "Estafan a Cubanos con 1.2 Millones de Pesos". EL ORBE. https://elorbe.com/rojas/2021/09/10/estafan-a-cubanos-con-1-2-millones-de-pesos.html
14. Green, 2024. "Los migrantes se enfrentan a secuestros masivos al pasar por México mientras el país amplifica su cooperación migratoria con Estados Unidos". ProPublica. https://www.propublica.org/article/inmigracion-mexico-us-migrantes-secuestros-masivos-carteles-frontera
15. Guillen, 2025. "El pueblo mexicano que desaparece a los migrantes". EL PAÍS. https://elpais.com/mexico/2025-11-23/el-pueblo-mexicano-que-desaparece-a-los-migrantes.html

Appendix: Our methodology and data dictionary

Our open-source code and additional documentation can be accessed in the following reposistories:

- Data cleaning and analysis; creation of source files for graphics:

------> http://github.com/lilianafrankel/traslados_INM

- Scrolly-telling visualization and interactive map:

------> http://github.com/jdanielgoh/traslados-migracion

Regarding our use of artifical intelligence technologies [AI]: The concatenation and cleaning of the original data relied on a close reading that was then systematized in Jupyter Notebook using Python; the map of historical routes was done in QGIS; the data analysis was conducted in Jupyter Notebook using Python; and the graphs created for this report were made in Flourish and Canva. During these processes, we utilized Claude's free Sonnet model as a reference for specific formulas and program functions. Our data were never directly loaded into the AI, nor did we rely on AI to generate any writing, opinions, or translations.

Table of Contents

1. Cleaning the official data
2. Creating the map of routes
3. Analysis of transfers' direction, correspondence with historical routes and detention infrastructure, and regional diversity

Cleaning the official data

Methodology

1. The main database was received as a response to an information request to the INM filed in the Plataforma Nacional de Transparencia. It covers the period from 2017-2023 and the first half of 2024.
2. The following information was received in eight tables, organized by year. They had the following categories:
    - Oficina de Representación del INM - Regional INM office
    - Lugar de origen - Place of origin
    - Lugar de destino - Destination
    - Total de migrantes en traslado - Number of immigrants aboard
    - Nacionalidad - Nationality
    - Hombres - Men
    - Mujeres - Women
    - Niñas - Girls
    - Niños - Boys
3. To these initial columns, we added the columns id_fila_og, which contains a unique ID number for each original row, and id_viaje, which contains a unique ID for each trip, which can span multiple original rows due to how the data was formatted.
4. The automatic cleaning of the tables was not straightforward; certain cells were combined to created overarching tags for the data, while others were combined to permit a more precise breakdown of the categories requested. The meaning of how cells were combined and divided also varied greatly from year to year and between participating regional INM offices. As such, the first step we took was to identify the rules each regional office followed to compile its data through a close reading of the database.
5. First, the specific rules were identified, along with the data ranges to which they corresponded. Next, all of the specific rules were examined to see if some could be combined and resolved through the same algorithm, in order to create a more efficient process. Finally, the column “regla” was created and each row was designated with the rule it would follow to be concatenated into the master table with all 8 years of data. Originally, 11 specific rules were identified, but through this process we could combine them into 4 rules and 2 special cases.
6. While the complete documentation of the original tables’ rules is linked in this footnote,[1] here we will mention a few of the interpretative decisions made in order to concatenate the tables, which became necessary when there were what seemed to be typos or inconsistencies in the original data. For example, the data of the Coahuila regional office in 2022 seem to be copy-pasted one column to the left of where they should have been. This error was interpreted and corrected as a typo in order to be able to conserve the majority of the data.
7. In the 2023 table, the column “Lugar de origen” was named “Oficina de Representación del INM”, creating a duplicate column in what seemed to be a typo. The places of origin were still largely broken down into localities in this table, but others were more vague, only repeating the name of the regional office; for example, Nuevo León and Estado de México. For such entries, the real-world addresses of each regional office were located in order to be able to conserve the data and visualize the transfers by municipality; for example, Nuevo León became Guadalupe, Nuevo León[2] and Estado de México became Toluca, Estado de México.[3]

8. In the 2024 table, various Michoacán entries only show Mexicans being transferred, which may represent US deportations of Mexican nationals to Michoacán. These rows weren't eliminated from our analysis, since they appear to form part of the infrastructure of return and deportation routes, but they are a noteworthy case within the trend.
9. After applying the rules, rows were eliminated if they still had blank values for lugar_origen, lugar_destino, total_migrantes_traslado, and/or nacionalidad. Rows for which lugar_origen, lugar_destino or nacionalidad had a number instead of a string (for example the rows with fila_id_og IDs 2778 to 2780) were also eliminated. And rows were checked and corrected if total_migrantes_traslados was a string instead of a number. If a row lacked all demographic data, it was eliminated; if just a few of the numbers within the sex and age breakdown were missing, for example in the case of Puebla in 2024, the row was conserved and the blank data was filled with 0's.
10. There are rows for which the sum of the demographic categories registered doesn't coincide with total_migrantes_traslado, but we decided to assume that the total was correct and that the errors present were more likely in the demographic breakdown. The decision to maintain rows with this irregular data as they came was made in recognition that for the analysis at hand, the demographic data received was broken down in excess of what was strictly required; we only needed to verify the presence or absence (binary value) and the total number (sum) of boys and girls on each transfer. If there were errors in the number of children registered, comparing it would total_migrantes_traslado would do nothing to resolve it, so we stuck with the information we were provided.
11. Once the full table was compiled, munipality and state names were standardized using Python. The majority of these names could be assigned exactly, but origins and destinations registered to "Ciudad de México" or "CDMX" were divided between the municipalities of Cuauhtémoc and Iztapalapa, which is an estimation.

Limitations

The variations in how different regional offices organized their data, as well as the discrepancies between the totals of the demographic breakdown versus the column total_migrantes_traslado, together suggest a highly manual and discretional documentation culture in the INM, producing archives with low levels of internal standarization. We don't have a way to find out the methodology that guided the creation of these records, but we tried to compensate for their inconsistencies by taking care to document our own process of concatenation and attempting to recuperate the greatest possible instance of relevant data. Even so, we recognize that our data represent an estimation of the historical reality rather than an exact portrait.

---

1. Frankel, 2026. "Reglas tablas". https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/17OCfRHTOGVZ7WL_YxtLJe7dqQxjmPX-1wGMM3uXzsgY/edit?gid=1896445730#gid=1896445730
2. "Nuevo León". Gobierno de México. https://www.inm.gob.mx/gobmx/word/index.php/nuevo-leon/
3. "Estado de México". Gobierno de México. https://www.inm.gob.mx/gobmx/word/index.php/estado-de-mexico/

Creating the map of routes

Purpose and final product:

- We wanted to create a map with nodes and lines representing the key points through which transit migration in Mexico has historically tended to pass
- The routes mapped should reflect as closely as possible the real routes of the freight train and interstate highway routes that represent the most efficient ways that people on the move could transit Mexico from south to north; in other words, they should represent paths of least resistance
- The route analysis should allow us to consistently analyze:
    - the direction, in relation of the map of routes from north to south, of each INM transfer
    - if the destination of each transfer was along one of the main historical transit migration routes, on an alternate route, or outside of any documented historical route; in other words, the correspondence of each INM transfer with the map of historical routes

Methodology:

1. Nodes and their connections were identified with reference to:
    - our own fieldwork
    - the fastest highway routes between key points as generated by the algorithms of Google Maps
    - the Map of Routes, Assistance and Risks Associated with Irregular Migration [RARAMIR][1] maintained by the Mexican government secretary's Immigration Policy Unit
    - a variety of historical maps of transit migration routes through Mexico, for example the map in a report by Amnesty International Mexico (2010),[2] the map in a Red de Fondos Ambientales de Latinoamérica y el Caribe report (2024),[3] and the map included in the book *Walking Together: Central Americans and Transit Migration through Mexico.*[4]
2. The nodes were loaded as points in QGIS with reference to the base map provided by Open Street Maps.
3. The official open route databases were downloaded from the National Railway Network [RFN] (2024) and the National Network of Roads [RNC] (2025), then uploaded to QGIS.
4. The railway routes were filtered to only include freight routes currently in operation. The road routes were filtered to only include federal and state highways; later, these filtered routes were combnied and cleaned in QGIS and GRASS to form a continuous network, creating the base network vías_principales.
5. To each key point we identified, we added a peripheral ring which looped its center point at a distance of 5-10 kilometers, depending on the city's size, so that the routing algorithm could select the most efficient entry and exit points to the city as a whole, independently of its center point. These peripheral rings were incorporated to vías_principales.
6. The routes were generated by segments between each of the key points identified using QGIS's Network Analysis function. In the few cases where it wasn't possible to generate a route using just vías_principales, we added back the smaller roads omitted in step 4.
7. Each route segment was checked visually to ensure its basic correspondence with vías_principales:
    - The majority of the routes generated followed vías_principales exactly.

- Almost all of the deviations observed followed either smaller roads or the auto-generated peripheral rings for very short distances.
- Of the very few remaining deviations that didn't follow either a smaller road or a peripheral ring, and were more likely the result of snaps or the cleaning of intersections, none was so drastic as to cross municipal lines.

8. The route segments generated were combined in four long routes from the southern border to central Mexico [Pacífico, Chiapas, Tabasco, Caribe], and five long routes from central Mexico to the northern border with the US [Baja, Sonora, Chihuahua, Texas, Golfo]. The southern routes are differentiated by their origins, and the northern routes, by their destinations. However, in central Mexico, many of the routes overlap.
9. Any of the southern routes can connect to any of the northern routes, generating 20 possible routes from one border to the other. However, these possible route combinations can be organized into two categories. The Pacific route can be assumed to be the main route leaving the southern border, since its origins are the most highly transited border crossings. For any northern route – Baja, Sonora, Chihuahua, Texas, or Golfo – we can assume the Pacific route as its probable origin. The alternative southern routes, Chiapas, Tabasco and Caribe, generally have a secondary weight in the analysis, with the exception that for the northern Golfo route, the southern Tabasco route can also be considered a probable origin, since this combination is the literal shortest route from south to north. The northern routes were all weighted equally, since immigrants' choice of crossing point to the US usually responds to their personal assessment of the security situation, where their family in the US already lives, and highly changeable online rumors about US border security. As such:
    - The main routes are: pacifico_baja, pacifico_sonora, pacifico_chihuahua, pacifico_texas, pacifico_golfo and tabasco_golfo;
    - The alternative routes are: chiapas_baja, chiapas_sonora, chiapas_chihuahua, chiapas_texas, chiapas_golfo, tabasco_baja, tabasco_sonora, tabasco_chihuahua, tabasco_texas, caribe_baja, caribe_sonora, caribe_chihuahua, caribe_texas, caribe_golfo.
10. The southern and northern routes connect in a few cities in central Mexico; the case of Puebla was the most complex, since it was originally classified as part of both the northern and the southern routes. In order to avoid confusions, it was later reclassified as part of the northern routes.

Limitations:

In the RNC and RFC databases, there are no indicators of direction in the routes that became the basis for vías_principales. However, we assume that since the routes selected were almost entirely main thoroughfares, there were likely few one-way routes among them; we also assume that any one-way routes were likely doubled by another one-way route in the other direction that didn't present many differences in the order of the municipalities it crossed.

The route map and designation of main versus alternative routes were designed to show paths of least resistance while consciously omitting an important factor: how people on the move tend to change their minds. We only mapped the connections between nodes in the order that they would be passed through by a person who, starting from their point of origin on the southern border, already had firmly in mind the point on the northern border to which they hoped to arrive, and was attempting to get there as quickly as possible.

1. Unidad de Política Migratoria, 2025. “Mapa de Rutas, Asistencia, y Riesgos Asociados a la Movilidad Irregular por México. Gobierno de México. https://politicamigratoria.segob.gob.mx/es/PoliticaMigratoria/raramir
2. Amnistía Internacional, 2010. “Víctimas Invisibles”. https://www.amnesty.org/es/wp-content/uploads/sites/4/2021/06/amr410142010es.pdf
3. Morales, 2024. “Las rutas migratorias en México”. Twitter. https://x.com/moaimx/status/1829950565947977832
4. Díaz de León, 2023. “Walking Together: Central Americans and Transit Migration through Mexico”. University of Arizona Press.

Analysis of transfers' direction, correspondence with historical routes and detention infrastructure, and regional diversity

Purpose:

- Assign the direction of each transfer with reference to the map of historical routes
- Determine the level of correspondence of each transfer with the historical route, with reference to the map generated
- Determine the regional diversity of people present on each transfer
- Indicate if there was immigrant detention infrastructure present in the origin and destination points of each transfer, using the information compiled by the CNDH in 2024[1]

Data dictionary:

For datos_menores_regiones (includes deportations):

Column name	Description
id_fila_og	Unique ID for each row that is consistent from its first appearance in the original data through every transmutation and final product
year	Year of transfer
oficina_regional	Contributing INM regional office
lugar_origen	The municipality and state of origin
lugar_destino	The destination municipality and state
total_migrantes_traslado	The number of people aboard
nacionalidades_orig	The nationalities of those aboard in their original phrasing
hombres	Number of men aboard
mujeres	Number of women aboard
niñas	Number of girls aboard
niños	Number of boys aboard
regla	The rule guiding how how this transfer was incorporated into the concatenation of the eight original tables[2]

id_viaje	Unique ID number assigned to each transfer on the basis of rows which had values for total_migrantes_traslado in the original tables; maintained from its assignation through every transmutation and final product
origen_limpio_mun	Origin municipality name
origen_limpio_ent	Origin state name
destino_limpio_mun	Destination municipality name
destino_limpio_ent	Destination state name
destino_cve	Unique ID assigned by Mexico's National System of Statistical and Geographical Information [INEGI] for the destination municipality
origen_cve	Unique ID assigned by Mexico's National System of Statistical and Geographical Information [INEGI] for the origin municipality
geom_destino	Geographical and geometric data
geom_origen	Geographical and geometric data
lon_destino	Longitude of the destination
lat_destino	Latitude of the destination
lon_origen	Longitude of the origin
lat_origen	Latitude of the origin
sentido	• **ava** if the transfer advanced those aboard along their routes • **ret** if it returned them • **lat** if it moved them laterally between parallel sites • **int** if it was within a single municipality • **dep** if it was a deportation
menores_num	Sum of the columns niñas + niños
menores_bin	1 if menores_num > 0; 0 if menores_num = 0
norteamerica	1 if in nacionalidades_orig there were North Americans; 0 if not
centroamerica	1 if in nacionalidades_orig there were Central Americans; 0 if not
sudamerica	1 if in nacionalidades_orig there were South Americans; 0 if not
caribe	1 if in nacionalidades_orig there were Caribbeans; 0 if not
extracontinentales	1 if in nacionalidades_orig there were people from outside the continent; 0 if not
nan_región	1 if in nacionalidades_orig there were people from unidentified regions; 0 if not
diversity	Sum of columns norteamerica + centroamerica + sudamerica + caribe + extracontinentales
diversity_cat	"Una región" if diversity = 1, "Dos o más regiones" if diversity > 1

Additional columns in datos_visualizables (just internal transfers):

rutas_posibles_o	List of routes on which the origin municipality is included
rutas_posibles_d	List of routes on which the destination municipality is included

correspondencia	• **ruta_cont_1** if both origin and destination municipalities are along a main route, or within the same route • **ruta_cont_2** if origin and destination municipalities are along any continuous alternative route • **rutas_diferentes** if origin and destination municipalities are on parallel routes • **d_fuera** if the destination isn't on any route • **o_fuera** if the origin isn't on any route • **ambos_fuera** if neither origin, nor destination are on a route
em_o	1 if the origin municipality has detention infrastructure; 0 if not
em_d	1 if the destination municipality has detention infrastructure; 0 if not
ems	• If em_o + em_d = 0, **no_em** • If = 1 y em_o = 1, **em_o** • If = 1 y em_d = 1, **em_d** • If = 2, **ambos**

Methodology

To determine direction

The direction of each transfer route was evaluated in reference to the previously generated map of historical routes. Its designation was manually registered, then assigned to all instances of the given transfer route, and checked visually during different phases of the visualization process.

To determine correspondence with historical routes

1. All routes were given buffers of 5 km, so that the final analysis could take nearby rest stops into account.
2. The municipalities crossed by each buffered route were extracted from the historical route map using the Select function in QGIS. In Central Mexico, the routes could coincide, meaning that a single municipality might be on multiple routes.
3. The extracted municipalities were added to a CSV and compared in Python with the origin and destination points documented for each INM transfer. The columns rutas_posibles_o and rutas_posibles_d were created to list the routes which crossed each origin and destination point.
4. Using the criteria described in the data dictionary, the column "correspondencia" was created.
5. For the final analysis of correspondence which appears in this report:
    - Transfers with the value "ruta_cont_1" were categorized as ending "Along a main route"
    - Transfers with the value "ruta_cont_2" or "rutas diferentes" were categorized as ending "Along an alternate route"
    - Transfers with the value "d_fuera" or "ambos_fuera" were categorized as ending "Outside established routes"
    - Transfers with the value "o_fuera" were categorized as ending "Along a main route" if their destination was along a main route, and categorized as ending "Along an alternate route" if their destination was only along an alternate route

Para describe transfers' correspondence with maps of detention infrastructure

1. The reference table "EMs" was created using CNDH data. It shows where the INM has reported detention infrastructure, including each center's municipality, state, CVEGEO, and estimated year inaugurated. Some detention centers didn't contain information about their inauguration date; these were left as 0s.
2. For each transfer, the municipalities of origin and destination were compared with EMs to check if they had any kind of detention infrastructure documented as operating there during the year the transfer took place. Depending on the result, they were assigned values for the columns em_o, em_d, and ems as documented in the data dictionary.

Limitations:

Los datos el INM son inexactos; una colega que realizó una solicitud similar a la nuestra sobre los traslados de personas migrantes recibió una base de datos también extensa, pero con datos diferentes; y el CNDH documenta que la información proporcionada por el INM respecto a las estaciones migratorias difirió de la misma información que la Comisión solicitó del INM en 2019. Parecería que el mismo INM no cuenta con registros consistentes y facilmente asequibles respecto a las operaciones de todos sus sitios de detención migratoria, lo que resalta que otra vez, este análisis describe y estima la realidad, pero no podemos afirmar que lo retrate en cada detalle.

---

1. CNDH, 2024. "Informe Especial sobre las Condiciones de las Estancias y Estaciones Migratorias: Hacia un Nuevo Modelo para la Atención de la Migración Irregular". CNDH. https://www.cndh.org.mx/sites/default/files/documentos/2024-02/INFORME%20ESPECIAL%20ESTANCIAS%20MIGRATORIAS.pdf
2. Frankel, 2026. "Reglas tablas". https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/17OCfRHTOGVZ7WL_YxtLJe7dqQxjmPX-1wGMM3uXzsgY/edit?gid=1896445730#gid=1896445730